

Chapter 167-1

Liang Shi tried calling Chen Mian back, but Chen Mian had already turned off her phone.

With no other choice, she called Xu Qingzhu while heading out. "Are you about to get off work?"

"Not yet," Xu Qingzhu said. "I still have some documents to process."

After saying that, her voice became somewhat cheerful. "Are you already downstairs?"

"Not yet." Liang Shi got in the car, put on her Bluetooth earpiece, and started the engine. "I just left."

"Huh?" Xu Qingzhu drew out her voice and reminded her, "Then be careful on the road."

"Oh, when you come over..." Xu Qingzhu's words collided with Liang Shi's. "Babe, Chen Mian just called me and asked me to pick up Wanwan from a bar. I'm going to head over."

Xu Qingzhu paused on her end. After a moment, Liang Shi asked, "What were you saying just now?"

"Nothing..." Xu Qingzhu held back her request. "Did something happen to Wanwan?"

"You first." Liang Shi's voice carried a smile. "When I come to pick you up, what do you want? Let me guess... Hmm, do you want mango pomelo sago?"

Xu Qingzhu laughed on her end, answering brightly, "Mm, no ice."

"Got it." Liang Shi asked, "Anything else? Want a small cake?"

"You can buy one too," Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi asked if she had any other requests. Xu Qingzhu thought about it but didn't have anything else.

The two chatted for a bit before hanging up.

Liang Shi told her she could take her time with the documents and rest if she got tired.

Xu Qingzhu laughed. "Who slacks off while working overtime?"

Liang Shi said helplessly, "You can't overwork yourself."

"I know," Xu Qingzhu said.

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Liang Shi arrived quickly.

This bar was more of a lounge bar. The style and music weren't too over the top. Since it wasn't peak hours yet, the bar's lights weren't flashing—they were just somewhat dim and dusky.

As soon as Liang Shi entered, she saw Liang Wanwan sitting at the bar counter with both arms pillowed under her head.

Chen Mian was standing beside Liang Wanwan, posture somewhat slack, looking down at her phone.

"Chen Mian." Liang Shi jogged over and called out to her.

Chen Mian put away her phone. "You're one minute late."

Liang Shi: "..."

"What happened?" Liang Shi glanced at Liang Wanwan, who was already passed out drunk, and went over to help her up.

Chen Mian didn't even make a move to help.

"She drank too much," Chen Mian said.

Liang Shi: "..."

"I know." Liang Shi couldn't help but retort, "I can see that. I'm asking why she got drunk. Was she bullied at school? Or was it something else? And you—what's going on with you? You said nothing was wrong, so why did you insist that I come pick her up?"

"You're her sister," Chen Mian said.

Liang Shi: "..."

"You can ask her about the rest." Chen Mian put one hand in her pocket. "After this, she and I won't be seeing each other again."

Liang Shi was surprised. "Did you two have a fight? Because of something at school?"

She did know that the two had been collaborating on something at school. Liang Wanwan had mentioned it to her once before.

"No." Chen Mian pressed her lips together lightly but still didn't explain.

Liang Shi found it strange, but she also knew she couldn't get anything out of Chen Mian. So she simply took Liang Wanwan and left first.

Chen Mian maintained her cold demeanor throughout, expressionless.

Even when they first met, she had been like this.

But today, she gave Liang Shi the feeling that she was deliberately avoiding something.

Later, Liang Shi noticed that from start to finish, Chen Mian hadn't looked at Liang Wanwan even once.

Liang Shi took Liang Wanwan home, then on the way to Xu Qingzhu's company, she bought mango pomelo sago and cake before picking up Xu Qingzhu. Downstairs, she also ran into Sally and Lin Luoxi, and incidentally... received their wedding invitations.

The date was set for Little New Year's Eve.¹

Liang Shi looked the two of them over and smiled. "Congratulations."

Sally patted her shoulder. "You have to come!"

People who were already married couldn't be bridesmaids, so both Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi could only attend as guests.

On the way back, Xu Qingzhu put in a straw and held the cup as she drank. After walking for a while, she finally remembered to ask, "What about Wanwan?"

"Passed out drunk." Liang Shi said, "I put her in the guest bedroom."

"She doesn't seem like a kid who'd drink heavily. Did something happen?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi shook her head. "I have no idea."

After a moment, Liang Shi added, "But I have a feeling it has something to do with Chen Mian."

Chen Mian's attitude was very strange.

After Liang Shi got home, she received a message from Chen Mian: 【Did Gu Xingyue make me hear "Flock of Lonely Birds"?】

Liang Shi hesitated, not knowing how to reply, so she set it aside.

But while she was chatting with Xu Qingzhu, her phone buzzed.

Xu Qingzhu thought it was hers and picked it up, only to see new messages from Chen Mian.

Chen Mian: 【Have you met Qi Jiao?】

Chen Mian: 【Was it Qi Jiao who wanted me to hear "Flock of Lonely Birds"?】

Chen Mian: 【Where did you see Qi Jiao?】

Xu Qingzhu read them aloud to Liang Shi.

Liang Shi had her reply: 【Qi Jiao passed away.】

But Chen Mian responded: 【Where did you see her? Take me there.】

1. Little New Year's Eve (小年): A traditional Chinese festival that falls on the 23rd or 24th day of the twelfth lunar month, about a week before Chinese New Year. It marks the beginning of the New Year celebration period and is traditionally associated with worshipping the Kitchen God. ↵

Chapter 167-2

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Chen Mian was a very stubborn person.

After getting back, Liang Shi had a phone call with Chen Mian.

Liang Shi asked Chen Mian why she was so certain it was Qi Jiao who said it. Chen Mian said she had a dream.

In the dream, someone was running a shop. Flowers bloomed at the entrance, and there was a blue sign. Qi Jiao was standing at the door.

Qi Jiao was smiling gently, and the person standing across from her was Liang Shi.

Chen Mian was the first person who dared to come questioning Liang Shi based solely on a dream.

But Liang Shi couldn't bring herself to fabricate lies to deceive her.

Because the dream was real.

The sign for "Deep Sea Sleepless" was indeed blue. Qi Jiao had indeed opened a flower shop. And Liang Shi had indeed met her.

After thinking for a long time, Liang Shi finally answered, "Qi Jiao went to another world."

Chen Mian then asked, "How can I get to that world?"

Liang Shi paused, then said helplessly, "You can't anymore."

The system had said that repairs to the plane world were underway, and the space-time gate had been closed.

And she would no longer be traveling between the two plane worlds.

Chen Mian was silent for a long time on her end before asking, "Is she doing well?"

"Very well," Liang Shi answered.

That was the only thing Chen Mian asked about. She didn't ask why Liang Shi could go to that world, nor did she ask why Liang Shi knew these things. The only thing she was interested in was Qi Jiao.

After hanging up, Liang Shi still felt somewhat melancholic.

Xu Qingzhu asked her what was wrong. She shook her head and smiled. "Sometimes I feel like fate is too cruel."

Lovers destined never to be together.

Xu Qingzhu teased her for being so sentimental. Liang Shi didn't say anything.

As for Liang Wanwan, she woke up the next day, left a note apologizing and thanking them, and then departed.

However, Liang Wanwan had written in the note that Guo Xinran was entering the entertainment industry, warning Liang Shi to be careful and not run into her.

Liang Shi later messaged Liang Wanwan, asking if something had happened at school.

Liang Wanwan replied: 【There was something, but it wasn't serious. It's already over now.】

Liang Shi: 【That's good then.】

Meanwhile, at that moment, Liang Wanwan was standing on the school's sports field. She suddenly crouched down, buried her head in her knees, and burst into tears.

Her secret love had ended in this bleak winter.

The moment a secret love is spoken aloud, it's destined to perish.

Because of this, Chen Mian had blocked her on WeChat, added her phone number to her blacklist, and even withdrew from the project she had been collaborating on with Liang Wanwan's advisor. A clean break, leaving no room for anything.

Chen Mian's words kept echoing in Liang Wanwan's mind: "I have someone I like."

"I know." Liang Wanwan had said. "It's Qi Jiao, right? I don't mind."

The drunk Liang Wanwan had boldly poured out her heart. "I can wait for you to forget her and move on."

"I won't forget," Chen Mian said.

Liang Wanwan tugged at the hem of her clothes. "Then... can you pretend I'm her?"

Chen Mian's gaze was fixed directly on her, cold without a trace of warmth.

"You don't need to settle for less." Chen Mian said, "We're not compatible."

Chen Mian pulled her hand away.

After that, Liang Wanwan couldn't remember how much she had drunk—only that it was after Chen Mian left.

Cup after cup, until she passed out there.

She didn't know how she ended up at Liang Shi's place, but when she woke up, she discovered Chen Mian had already blocked her.

So decisively done.

It extinguished all of Liang Wanwan's flames of love and snuffed out all her hopes.

Chapter 167-3

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Chen Mian also drank all night at home, drunk the entire night.

She had "Flock of Lonely Birds" playing on repeat.

On the canvas, she had painted the same person she'd been painting for decades.

Chen Mian dreamed of Qi Jiao—a Qi Jiao who was talking and laughing cheerfully.

When she woke from the dream, it was all empty. "Flock of Lonely Birds" was reaching its end, stopping right at those lyrics:

"The lonely bird flies into the galaxy, boarding a ship

Someone raises the sail

Someone waits at the other end"

Chen Mian called Gu Xingyue like a madwoman, asking if she had ever heard "Flock of Lonely Birds."

Gu Xingyue was taken aback and told her no.

The image of Qi Jiao from the dream kept appearing in Chen Mian's mind. Then she called Liang Shi to confirm.

Everything was real.

But it seemed like there was nothing she could do about it anymore.

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Liang Shi didn't know what had happened between Chen Mian and Liang Wanwan.

She just found it strange.

Later, when she asked Xu Qingzhu, Xu Qingzhu mysteriously refused to tell her, only saying she was too dense.

Liang Shi: "..."

"Really." Liang Shi said very earnestly, "Before I met you, I always thought I was pretty smart."

Xu Qingzhu glanced at her. "You are pretty smart."

Liang Shi: "Then why did you call me dense?"

Xu Qingzhu paused for a moment. "You're only dense when it comes to matters of the heart."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi pinched her waist. "Who told you to learn so fast?"

Xu Qingzhu was tickled and kept burrowing into her arms. "You're a poor student yourself. How can you blame the top student for your own slow learning?"

Liang Shi tickled her waist again. Xu Qingzhu turned around, and her teeth landed on Liang Shi's collarbone, bumping against it.

Xu Qingzhu gasped sharply. Startled, Liang Shi immediately pulled her hands back and didn't dare to play around anymore. She asked urgently, "Are you okay?"

Xu Qingzhu buried herself in Liang Shi's neck and let out a muffled grunt, not saying anything.

Liang Shi tried to look at her, thinking she might have hurt herself somewhere. But Xu Qingzhu refused to lift her head no matter what, staying buried in Liang Shi's neck.

Liang Shi apologized to her. "I'm sorry."

As soon as she finished speaking, she suddenly felt something wet on her collarbone.

"What are you doing?" Liang Shi's throat moved slightly. The sound of her swallowing was especially clear in the quiet room.

Xu Qingzhu's voice was very low. "You hurt my teeth, so I have to get payback with my tongue."

Liang Shi: "..."

Xu Qingzhu happened to look up at her slightly. Those eyes were sparkling. Liang Shi suddenly curved her lips into a light smile, then slowly leaned down.

She gave Xu Qingzhu a light peck on the lips. "Still want payback now?"

Xu Qingzhu: "...But..."

Before she could finish speaking, her words were completely swallowed up.

Liang Shi kept protecting the small of her back.

When the kiss ended, Xu Qingzhu buried herself in her neck to catch her breath. After a while, she moved close to Liang Shi's ear and whispered something.

Liang Shi's ears suddenly turned red.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together. "Why are you blushing?"

Liang Shi: "..."

What Xu Qingzhu had just said was: "I kind of want to. Do you want to?"

Liang Shi didn't speak for a long time. Xu Qingzhu turned to walk toward the bedroom, but as soon as she stood up from the sofa, Liang Shi grabbed her.

"What? You don't want to do it, so let me go." Xu Qingzhu said petulantly.

Liang Shi answered her in a low voice, "I do want to."

Then she added, "You were just too direct. I was embarrassed."

Xu Qingzhu: "I was already being very restrained. Is desire something so hard to talk about?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"Everyone has desires." Xu Qingzhu said, "We all learned this in health class. Did you never take health class?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Xu Qingzhu shook her head helplessly and said with a hint of exasperation, "You blockhead."

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi couldn't help herself. She leaned down and bit her earlobe.

Xu Qingzhu: "What are you doing?"

Liang Shi scooped her up in her arms. "Satisfying your desires."

Xu Qingzhu buried herself in her embrace and said in a low voice, "But... be careful of the baby."

Liang Shi licked her lips, her voice barely audible. "I can still take care of you."

Xu Qingzhu: "?"

"What did you say?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi set her down on the bed, then leaned close to her ear and repeated it.

This time it was Xu Qingzhu's ears that burned hot.

How did it feel like... Liang Shi was actually the one who knew more?